

Your Complete Guide to Reaching Varanasi

ROAD TO SALVATION

Varanasi, known as Kashi, showcases India's spiritual essence, nestled by the sacred Ganges. It stands as one of the world's oldest cities, resonating with centuries of spiritual, cultural, and historical significance. With its ancient temples and lively ghats, Varanasi attracts pilgrims and tourists each year, providing a unique exploration of India's spiritual values.

Referred by various names like Kashi, Avimukta, and Anandavana, Varanasi is believed to be the home of Lord Shiva, the Hindu god of destruction and rebirth. However, Varanasi is not only a spiritual center but also a hub of cultural traditions. Its narrow streets are a maze of sights, sounds, and scents, offering a glimpse into the diverse fabric of Indian society. With bustling markets selling silk sarees and handicrafts, as well as the tempting aroma of street food floating in the air, Varanasi is a sensory experience that enchants the senses and leaves a lasting impact on visitors.

Flying into Serenity: Arrival at Varanasi's Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport

Located in Babatpur, Varanasi International Airport, also known as Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport, is situated 26 kilometers northwest of Varanasi and serves the city and nearby areas. Handling domestic and international flights, the airport offers connectivity to major cities like Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, and Bengaluru, as well as international destinations such as Kathmandu, Sharjah, and Bangkok. Playing a vital role in promoting tourism and facilitating travel to and from Varanasi, the airport underwent extensive modernization and expansion recently to cater to the growing number of passengers. It features a single integrated terminal for both domestic and international flights, along with a range of passenger facilities like restaurants, shops, lounges, and car rental services.

Traversing the Tracks: Access by Train

Varanasi, the spiritual heart of India, welcomes travelers through its diverse railway network. Here's a detailed guide to the four stations that operate in this sacred city:

1. **Varanasi Junction (BSB):** Varanasi Junction, also referred to as Varanasi Cantt Railway Station, is the primary railway station for the city. Situated in the center of Varanasi it is the main railway hub of the city, offering connections to major Indian cities. It also provides various facilities for travelers like areas for passengers to sit while waiting, accommodations for those staying overnight, places to purchase food and

drinks, shops selling various items, banking services, parking for cars and taxis, and medical assistance.

2. **Banaras Railway Station (BSBS):** Also called Manduadih Railway Station, located 4 kilometers from the city center, it is a historical station and was the main station of Varanasi. It has 5 platforms, waiting rooms, and refreshment stalls. It offers express and passenger trains to different destinations, making it a good choice for travelers looking for a historic atmosphere and possibly cheaper ticket prices than Varanasi Junction.
3. **Kashi Railway Station (KEI):** Situated 5 kilometers away from the city center, this station provides connections to specific destinations. It is a smaller station with few amenities, mostly serving passenger trains linking Varanasi to nearby towns.
4. **Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Junction (DDU):** Also referred to as Mughalsarai Junction situated 18 kilometers from city center. It is an important station connecting northern and eastern India. The station boasts multiple platforms, waiting rooms, cloakrooms, refreshment stalls, and a prepaid taxi booth. Mainly serves long-distance trains bound for the northern regions of the country. Suitable for travelers on lengthy journeys who are willing to travel further from the city center for a broader range of train options or possibly cheaper ticket prices than stations closer to the city.

The Road to Reverence: Traveling to Varanasi by Road

Travelling by road to Varanasi provides a unique opportunity to explore India's diverse landscapes and cultures. Varanasi is well-connected by road to major cities in Uttar Pradesh and neighboring states, with highways like NH 19 and NH 31 passing through or near the city. The Eastern Peripheral Expressway and Purvanchal Expressway offer faster travel from Delhi and surrounding areas. You may encounter scenic countryside, rivers, and small towns along the way, showcasing rural life in India. Travel time can vary widely depending on your starting point, ranging from 4-6 hours from nearby cities to 10-12 hours from Delhi or Kolkata. Traffic congestion is common in urban areas, and road conditions can range from well-maintained highways to narrow, bumpy roads. Pit stops and amenities such as roadside eateries and fuel stations are available, allowing you to take breaks and sample local cuisine.

In Transit: Exploring Varanasi's Charms by Bus

Taking a bus to Varanasi is a convenient and budget-friendly way to reach the historic city. The city has multiple bus stations, including the *Chaudhary Charan Singh Bus Stand Varanasi*, nearly 1 km far from Varanasi Railway station. It is well-connected to major cities in Uttar Pradesh and neighboring states with a variety of state-run and private bus services. Travel times can vary, with journeys from nearby cities like Allahabad or Lucknow taking about 4-6 hours, while trips

from Delhi or Kolkata may take 10-12 hours. It's recommended to book bus tickets in advance, particularly during peak travel times.

Varanasi is a city that beckons travelers with its ancient charm and spiritual allure. Whether you choose to arrive by air, train, or road, the journey to this city is as enriching as the destination itself. So, plan your trip, immerse yourself in the city's rich culture and spirituality, and discover its timeless beauty.